

Course Description

Ethics, Communication, and Tools for Software Development

Class Number

CSC 300GW

Section

05

Semester

Fall 2025

Class Timings

Tue/Thurs: 11:00 AM – 12:15 PM

Instruction Mode

Face to Face Instruction

Room

Thornton Hall 331

Prerequisites

Prerequisite: grade C or better in CSC 210 or equivalent; grade C or better in English 214 or equivalent.

Instructor: Dr. Zainab Agha

Office: TH 965

Email: zainabagha@sfsu.edu

Communication: Please reach out to me via email or visit my office hours. Please frequently check Canvas for any announcements, discussions, or deadlines.

Office Hours: Thursdays, 2:00 – 3:00 PM in-person (TH 965) or via Zoom. If this does not work for you, please email me to set a time to meet. Zoom link for office hours:

<https://sfsu.zoom.us/j/9853004666?pwd=vK4U58lGzz1orKR6prMkyfggW8dm4V.1>

Description

This course explores the ethics of technology and how to be mindful of the harmful consequences and ethical implications of modern technology. One of the main goals for this course is to develop critical thinking regarding the technologies we use and develop. In doing so, we will focus on ethical reasoning as well as the nitty gritty of real-world applications, and you will develop practical skills in reading, writing, and discussing. During the semester, we will have wide-ranging discussions that include issues of: Privacy, freedom of

speech, content moderation, intellectual property, online risks, artificial intelligence, professional and research ethics.

Student Learning Outcomes

- Evaluate social and ethical issues that are associated with the access, control and distribution of online information or developing software.
- Understand the department's ethics and plagiarism policy.
- Understand, evaluate and apply various legal, privacy and intellectual property concerns related to online information and software.
- Understand professional responsibility, accountability when writing software.
- Use written and oral communication effectively in the context of computer science ethics and collaborative software development.

About Me: With a PhD in Computer Science from Vanderbilt University, my research focus area is Human-Computer Interaction and Online Safety. I care about building ethical and usable technology for people that helps them. Specifically, most of my work focuses on online safety and well-being of youth by developing and evaluating interventions that can help them in-the-moment they face a risk. Please visit me in my office hours to chat about the course, writing support, or anything else you would like to discuss. This time is for you, so I hope that you will utilize it.

Course Schedule (Tentative)

Week	Topic	Suggested Readings/Content
Week 1 (Aug. 25)	Introduction/ Course Overview	• Read: How to Write (Not Terrible) Philosophy Papers • Read: APA Citation Styles • Read: How to (seriously) read a scientific paper • In-Class Reading: A Sample Philosophy Paper
Week 2 (Sep. 1)	Ethics and Writing	• Read: What is ethics? • Read: Superhuman Ethics Class with The Avengers Prime • Watch: Crash Courses on Utilitarianism, Deontology, and Virtue Theory
Sep. 7, 11:59 pm	Writing Assignment #1 Due	
Week 3 (Sep. 8)	Ethics of Future Technology	• Read: Gift of Fire, Chapter 1 (p. 1-40) • Read: One crash set off a new era for self-driving cars in S.F. Here's a complete look at what happened
Sep. 15	Last Day to Drop Class/Withdraw	

Week 4 (Sep. 15)	Privacy and Corporations	• Read: Gift of Fire, Chapter 2, Sections 2.1, 2.2 and 2.6 • Read: Companies lose your data and then nothing happens • Read: How Cambridge Analytica Turned Facebook Likes Into a Lucrative Political Tool
Deadline: Sep. 21, 11:59 pm	Writing Assignment #2 Due	
Week 5 (Sep. 22)	Privacy and Government	• Read: Gift of Fire - Chapter 2, Sections 2.3-2.5 (p. 77-107) • Read: "Why a landmark kids online safety bill that just passed the Senate is still deeply divisive" • Watch: Government Surveillance on Last Week Tonight
Week 6 (Sep. 29)	Freedom of Speech/ Content Moderation	• Read: Gift of Fire - Chapter 3, Sections 3.1-3.3 & 3.5 • Read: More so than adults, U.S. teens value people feeling safe online over being able to speak freely • Read: "Did You Suspect the Post Would be Removed?": Understanding User Reactions to Content Removals on Reddit
Deadline: Oct. 5, 11:59 pm	Writing Assignment #3 Due	
Week 7 (Oct. 6)	Intellectual Property	• Read: Gift of Fire – Chapter 4, Sections 4.1, 4.2 & 4.5 • Watch: Introduction to Intellectual Property by CrashCourse • Read: "Why is Taylor Swift Re-Recording her Albums?" • Read: "Can Vans really sue Target for a cheap look-alike of its most famous skater shoe?"
Week 8 (Oct. 13)	Online Risks	• Read: "Dear Diary: Teens Reflect on Their Weekly Online Risk Experiences" • Read: "College student cyberbullying on social networking sites: Conceptualization, prevalence, and perceived bystander responsibility" • Read: "Online grooming crimes have risen by more than 80% in four years"
Deadline: Oct. 19, 11:59 pm	Writing Assignment #4 Due	

Week 9 (Oct. 20)	Information and Security Risks	• Gift of Fire – Chapter 5, Sections 5.1 – 5.4 • Read: “COVID-19 information disorder: six types of harmful information during the pandemic in Europe” • Read: “Teaching Johnny not to fall for phish”
Week 10 (Oct. 27)	Evaluating and Controlling Technology	• Read: Gift of Fire – Chapter 7, Sections 7.1 – 7.3 • Read: “Disability, Human Rights, And Social Justice: The Ongoing Struggle For Online Accessibility And Equality” • Read: “Why Amazon’s Automated Hiring Tool Discriminated Against Women”
Deadline: Nov. 2, 11:59 pm	Writing Assignment #5 Due	
Week 11 (Nov. 3)	Behavioral Interventions in Technology	• Read: Gift of Fire – Chapter 7, Sections 7.4 – 7.5 • Read: “Exploring Nudge Designs to Help Adolescent SNS Users Avoid Privacy and Safety Threats” • Read: “Instagram’s new ‘nighttime nudges’ aim to reduce teens’ time on the app”
Week 12 (Nov. 10)	Ethics of Artificial Intelligence	• Read: Which Ethical Implications Of Generative AI Should Companies Focus On? • Watch: AI can do your homework. Now what?
Week 13 (Nov. 17)	Professional Ethics	• Read: Gift of Fire – Chapter 9, Sections 9.1, 9.2 • Read: ACM Code of Ethics • Read: CS Department Ethics & Plagiarism Policy • Read: IEEE Code of Ethics for Engineers
(Nov. 25 – Nov. 29)	Thanksgiving Break/Fall Recess*	
Deadline: Nov. 30, 11:59 pm	Writing Assignment #6 Due	
Week 14 (Dec. 1)	Ethics of Computing Research/Presentations	• Read: “Beyond the Belmont Principles: Ethical Challenges, Practices, and Beliefs in the Online Data Research Community” • Read: “Facebook Manipulated User News Feeds To Create Emotional Responses”, Forbes, 2014. • Read: “Where are human subjects in Big Data research? The emerging ethics divide”
Week 15 (Dec. 8)	Presentations/Course Reflection	
Deadline: Dec. 14, 11:59 pm	Course Reflections Due	
Week 16 (Dec. 15)	No Final Exam	

Textbook/Readings:

The required textbook is "A Gift of Fire," 5th edition, by Sara Baase and Timothy Henry. It is important to get the correct edition of the book as the previous one is outdated. We will roughly follow the topics covered in this textbook, with some modifications. You can get your hands on the book through Amazon or Chegg. It is \$22 for an ebook, \$28 to rent, \$62 used, and \$75 new. I am working with the library to figure out alternatives as well. We will discuss access to the textbook further in the class.

At the start of the semester, we will discuss strategies for reading efficiently and effectively to engage with the weekly topics. Before each week, I will post announcements highlighting the mandatory and optional readings which may help you manage your time better. Please note that there may be graded class participation related to the mandatory readings, so it is important to come prepared.

Grading

- Attendance: 5%
- Class Presentation: 15%
- In-Class/Online Participation: 20% (This includes Canvas discussion posts, peer feedback on presentations, in-class writing/participation.)
- Writing Assignments: 60% (6 Writing Papers every other week, 10% per paper)

The grading scale used for this class is attached below.

Percentage Range	Letter Grade
100.00% - 93.00%	A
92.99% - 90.00%	A-
89.99% - 87.00%	B+
86.99% - 83.00%	B
82.99% - 80.00%	B-
79.99% - 77.0%	C+
76.99% - 73.00%	C
72.99% - 70.00%	C-
69.99% - 67.00%	D+
66.99% - 63.00%	D
62.99% - 60.00%	D-
59.99% - 0.00%	F

Disclaimer of Changes

This syllabus is subject to change. We will discuss further in class and any finalized changes will be posted on Canvas accordingly.

Attendance Policy

You are allowed 2 unexcused absences from the class, if you would like to use them. Please make sure to catch up on class content in case you are absent. All other absences will affect your grade. In case of exceptional circumstances, please reach out to me directly, with a 3-day notice before being absent from class.

Late Submission Policy

You are allowed one late submission throughout the semester, no questions asked. I recommend saving this late pass for unforeseen circumstances. After using that late submission pass, you are required to submit all assignments on time. Any future late submissions will be subject to a late penalty, and it is not guaranteed that submissions will be accepted for grading. In case of any exceptional circumstances, please reach out to me directly.

Accommodations for Religious Holidays Policy

The SFSU community recognizes and takes pride in the diversity of religious and spiritual backgrounds of its student body and strives to make every reasonable effort to give its students the opportunity to observe their recognized religious holidays. It is your responsibility to inform me, in writing, about such holidays during the first two weeks of the class. If such holidays occur during the first two weeks of the semester, you must notify me, in writing, at least three days before the date that you will be absent.

Disability Access

Students with disabilities who need reasonable accommodations are encouraged to contact the instructor. The Disability Programs and Resource Center (DPRC) is available to facilitate the reasonable accommodations process. The DPRC is located in the Student Service Building and can be reached by telephone (voice/415-338-2472, video phone/415-335-7210) or by email (dprc@sfsu.edu).

Disclosures of Sexual Violence (Title IX)

SF State fosters a campus free of sexual violence including sexual harassment, domestic violence, dating violence, stalking, and/or any form of sex or gender discrimination. If you disclose a personal experience as an SF State student, the course instructor is required to notify the Title IX Coordinator by completing the report form available at <https://titleix.sfsu.edu>, emailing vpsaem@sfsu.edu, or calling (415) 338-2032. To disclose any such violence confidentially, contact:

The SAFE Place – (415) 338-2208; http://www.sfsu.edu/~safe_plc/

Counseling and Psychological Services Center – (415) 338-2208; psyservs.sfsu.edu

For more information on your rights and available resources, visit <http://titleix.sfsu.edu>.

Academic Integrity

Academic integrity, the ethical presentation of one's own work in accordance with the rules established for this class, is required. Instances of academic misconduct will be reported to the College in which the course is housed, the Division of Graduate Studies (if a graduate student), and the Office of Student Conduct with the report being kept in

those offices until a student earns his/her degree. Any instances of cheating, deceit, fabrication, forgery, plagiarism, unauthorized altering of records or submitting false documents, unauthorized collaboration, unauthorized submission of work previously given credit, or other forms of academic misconduct will be assigned a grade penalty, likely an F or a grade of zero. Failing one or more assignments or examinations for reasons of academic integrity violations may result in a final class grade of F. Students may not withdraw from classes in which they have committed academic misconduct. Consequences for violations of academic integrity may exceed an F on the assignment, examination, or class as determined by the Academic Integrity Review Committee.

Members of our academic community have a responsibility to develop an awareness of academic integrity, to cultivate skills to realize honesty in academic and community work, and to sustain actively academic honor as a core value of our community. Students are expected to engage in behaviors that reflect well upon the university. In addition to attending to one's own actions, the Standards for Student Conduct require that students who witness academic dishonesty notify their faculty/instructor, department chair, or the Office of Student Conduct. Supporting academic integrity enhances the reputation of the University and the value attributed to degrees awarded by the University.

AI Policy

AI tools can be an aid in the research and writing process. But they can contain misinformation, problematic simplifications, bias, and discriminatory language. In fact, we will have assignments in this course where we will use ChatGPT for writing to analyze and critique the output. Unless specified in the assignment, all assignments in this course must be your own original work. Below, I have outlined some ways in which you can and cannot use AI for this course. Remember, that if prohibited AI use is suspected or detected, you may be reported for academic misconduct.

Prohibited use:

- You may not have an AI program write a draft (either rough or final) of an assignment for you, unless specified by the professor.
- You may not use AI tools to generate ideas for your assignments or any component of the course. The goal of the course is to learn to think critically (on our own) about technology use (such as AI).
- You may not use entire sentences or paragraphs suggested by AI without providing quotation marks and a citation, just as you would to any other source.

Permitted use:

- You are free to use spell check and grammar check.
- You can use AI tools to generate images or visuals for any presentation or paper (if you wish to include visuals).
- You may use AI tools to correctly format your document.

In all the above cases, you must cite your sources. Always acknowledge any contribution from AI tools following proper citation guidelines. Here's one sample citation based on [APA](#):

OpenAI. (2023). ChatGPT (Mar 14 version) [Large language model].
<https://chat.openai.com/chat>

The goal is to use AI as a learning aid, not a shortcut. True understanding comes from critically thinking and expressing your unique perspectives independently.

Student Resources

- [TASC Writing Groups and Study Sessions](#): TASC, SF State's Tutoring and Academic Support Center offers online and on-campus tutoring. You can schedule appointments as needed, either with the friendly folks at TASC reception (LIB 220 and on Zoom), by email request (tutoring@sfsu.edu), or on your own using Navigator. Spring schedule:
 - Drop-in: Jan 27th, 2025 - May 23rd, 2025, Mon-Thu 9am-5pm, Fri 10am-2pm
 - Appointments: Feb 10th, 2025 - May 23rd, 2025 Mon-Thu 9am-5pm, Fri 10am-2pm (in-person, Mon-Thu 8am-8pm, Fri 10am-2pm (online)
- SFSU has a variety of resources for student support and success. You can find a list of Student Resources [here](#).